

couples take the time and effort to do short-range planning (a budget). I trust you are well on your way to doing that. But even fewer do ANY long-range financial planning. That's why they end up on Social Security at age 65.

14 QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS ON FAMILY FINANCES

Before discussing critical family issues, I would like to cover some of the most common questions that couples ask about budgeting. Since God's best is for a husband and wife to operate as a team, it's important to settle early who should do what. It is especially important for engaged couples to discuss their finances openly and honestly. If a deficiency is found in any area, then seek outside counsel.

QUESTION 1. Who should keep the books?

Both my fiancé and I like to keep track of the bills and our checking account. Whose responsibility should that be?

ANSWER: Actually, it is the responsibility of both husband and wife. Any budget requires input from both. Once the budget is established, then the better bookkeeper should maintain the records. Sometimes it's the husband; sometimes it's the wife.

I find with most couples I counsel that the wife, given training, is usually the better bookkeeper. Normally she has more time and is a little more diligent. With many couples, the husband starts out keeping the records but makes a mess of them, mostly through neglect. Quite often the wife then inherits them. Her first reaction upon taking over is panic. There may be unpaid bills, collection letters, and too little money. Usually the wife just makes a bigger disaster, because she hasn't been trained in how to even balance the checkbook. It's impossible to budget if you don't even know how much is in the bank.

I remember a young pastor who had a rather interesting